

What looks empty today will be tomorrow's meadows?

Traditional Slash-and-Burn practice in Hong Kong

Double Ninth Festival is a traditional holiday in Hong Kong and is a time to mourn the dead and worship their ancestors by visiting tombs and making offerings, these tributes involve burning of incense and joss paper in tomb sites mostly located on hillsides. The **Indigenous inhabitants** also perform a **Slash-and-Burn practice**, deliberately setting grassland or mountains next to their villages on fire, believing it would bring better yield of crops next year. So it is not surprising that Double Ninth Festival is often the day when the most wildfire are reported. On Double Ninth Festival in 2020, **72 wildfire cases** were reported over **5 hours** (1).

Benefits and Consequences of Slash-and-Burn

Increase Soil fertility Nutrient-rich layer of ash created by burning	✓	✗	Fire Hazard The fire can easily go out of control
Temporarily eliminating weed and pest species	✓	✗	Lost of habitat and species Animal can be eliminated if not cleared before burning.
Sustainable If done correctly	✓	✗	Soil Erosion Soil erode faster without the root system of plants
Increase in biodiversity in certain situations (4)	✓	✗	Air pollution Release of carbon into the atmosphere

Slash-and-Burn

It is a farming method that involves the cutting and burning of plants in a forest or woodland to create a field called a **swidden**.

Swidden cultivation has been one of the most important land use systems in the tropics, including Southeast Asia. In many situations it is in fact a rational economic and environmental choice for farmers in the humid tropics.(2)

The **Food and Agriculture Organization** claimed Slash-and-Burn is not only a backward type of agricultural practice but also a backward stage of culture in general. (3)

References

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